Menota's model of manuscript text and its current and future extensions

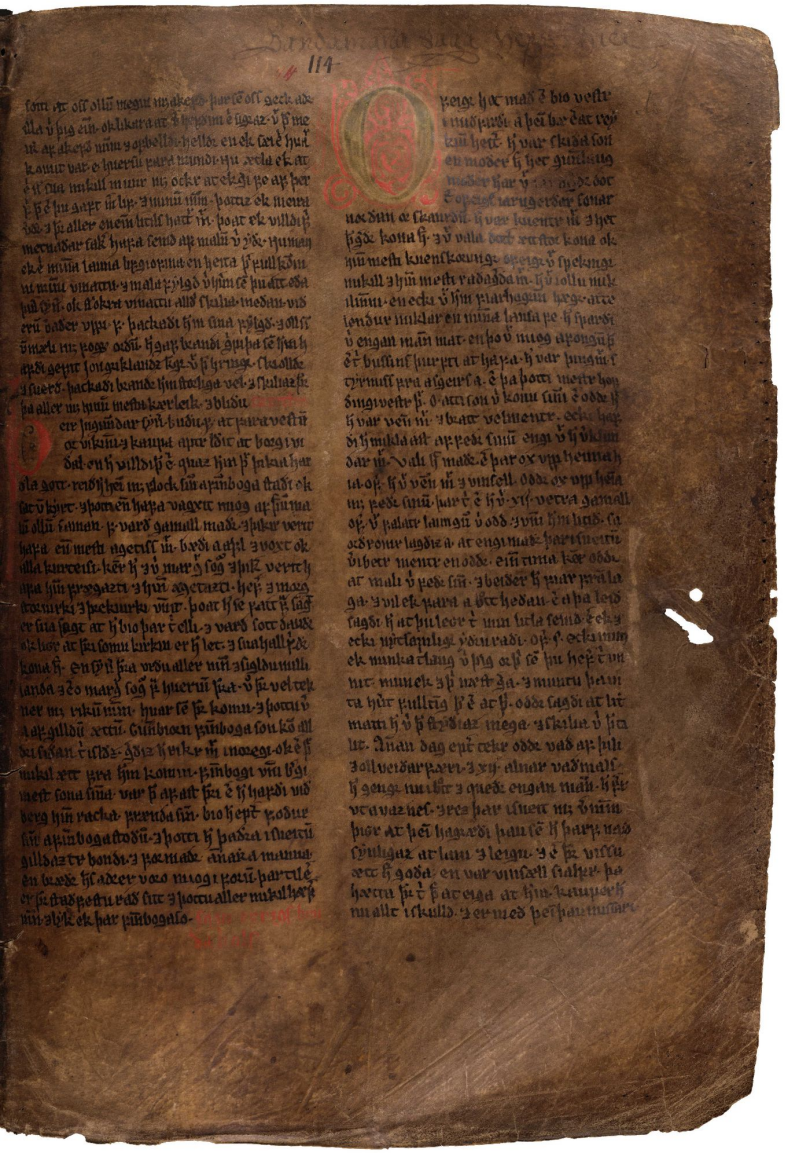
Tarrin Wills
Dictionary of Old Norse Prose

Menota Jubilee
10 September 2026



UNIVERSITY OF COPENHAGEN

1. Menota at 25: From texts to textual objects



AM 132 fol (114ra.41–120vb.21) – Bandamanna saga according to AM 132 fol (Möðruvallabók)

Page: 114r Facs Dipl Norm Clean text

[Facs]

[ms: fol. 114r]
[ms: col. a] 1.
41 ſaga oꝑeigſ ban
42 ða kalf
[ms: col. b]
1 Oꝑeigr heꞇ mað e̊ bío veſꞇr
2 ı miðꝑırðı a þeī bæ e̊ aꞇ rey
3 kıū heıꞇ. ħ var ſkıða ſon
4 en moðer fı̄ heꞇ gūnlaug
5 moðer ħar v̊ ıarnǥ̊ðr ðoꞇ
6 ꞇ oꝑeigſ ıarngerðar ſonar
7 norðan ór ſkaurðū. ħ var kuenꞇr m̄ ꝛ heꞇ
8 þǥ̊ðr kona fı̄. ꝛ v̊ vala ðoꞇꞇ ætꞇſꞇor kona ok
9 hīn meſꞇı kuenſkorungr. oꝑeıgr v̊ ſpekıngr
10 mıkıll ꝛ hīn meſꞇı raðaǥ̊ða m̄. ħ v̊ ı ollu mık
11 ılm̄nı. en eckı v̊ ħm ꝑıarhagrīn hægr. aꞇꞇe
12 lendur mıklar en mīna lauſa ꝑe. ħ ſparðı
13 v̊ engan mān maꞇ. en þo v̊ mıog a ꝑongū þ
14 e̊ ꞇ buſſīnſ þurꝑꞇı aꞇ haꝑa. ħ var þıngm̄. ſ
15 ꝛyrmuſſ rra aſgeırſ á. e̊ ba boꝛꞇı meſꞇr hor

[Dipl]

[ms: fol. 114r]
[ms: col. a] 1.
41 ſaga ofeigſ ban·
42 da kalf
[ms: col. b]
1 Ofeigr het mað er bío veſtr
2 i miðfirði a þeim bæ er at rey·
3 kium heiter. hann var ſkiða ſon
4 en moðer hanſ het gunnlaug
5 moðer hennar var iarngerdr dot·
6 ter ofeigſ iarngerðar ſonar
7 norðan ór ſkaurðum. hann var kuentr
8 þorgerðr kona hanſ. ok var vala
9 hinn meſti kuenſkorungr. ofeig
10 mikill ok hinn meſti raðagerða
11 ilmenni. en ecki var honum fia
12 lendur miklar en minna lauſa fe
13 við engan mann mat. en þo var
14 er til buſſinſ þurfti at hafa. han

```
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 <me:facs>he&trot;</me:facs>
 <me:dipl>het</me:dipl>
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2. What Menota got right

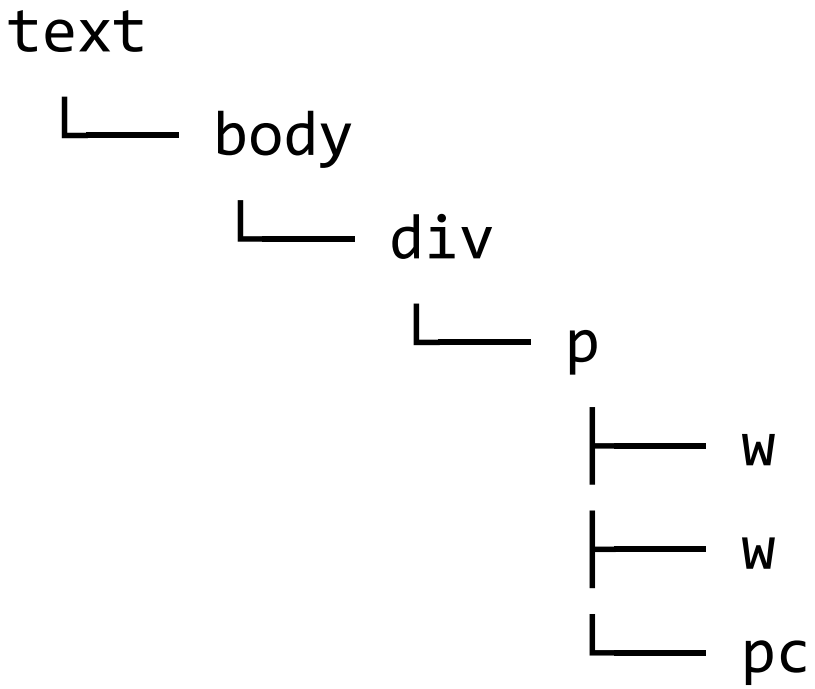
Integrating four aspects of the medieval textual object:

MANUSCRIPT → TEXT → EDITION → LANGUAGE

- physical/layout structure
  - (page/column/line breaks, image links)
- textual structure
  - TEI/XML
- editing traditions - in parallel
  - Manuscript, diplomatic, normalised
- linguistic structure
  - POS-tagging: lemmatisation, morphosyntactic analysis

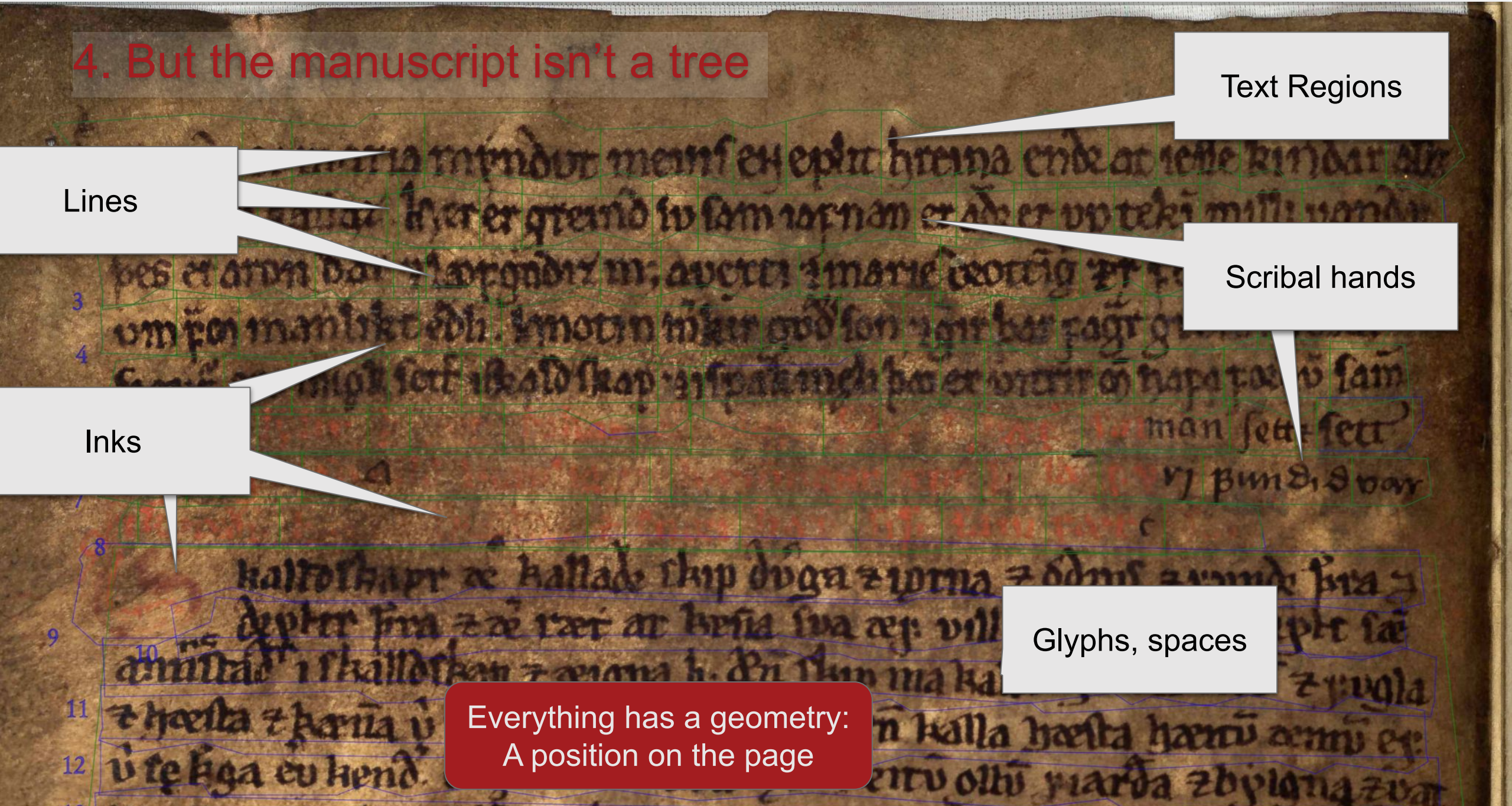
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<w lemma="heita" me:msa="xVB fF tPT mIN p3 nS vA">
 <me:facs>he&trot;</me:facs>
 <me:dipl>het</me:dipl>
```

3. The extraordinary durability of the XML tree for text

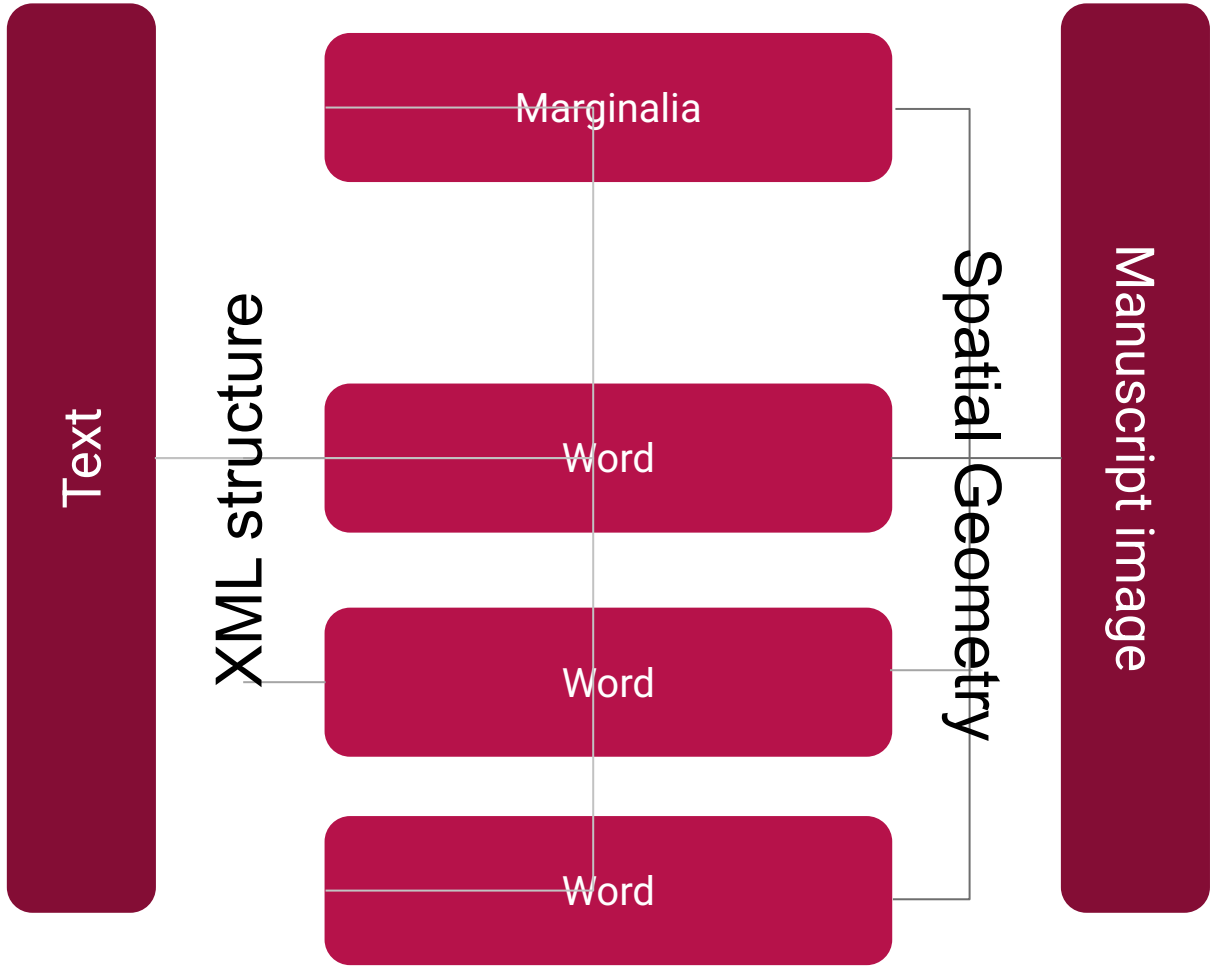


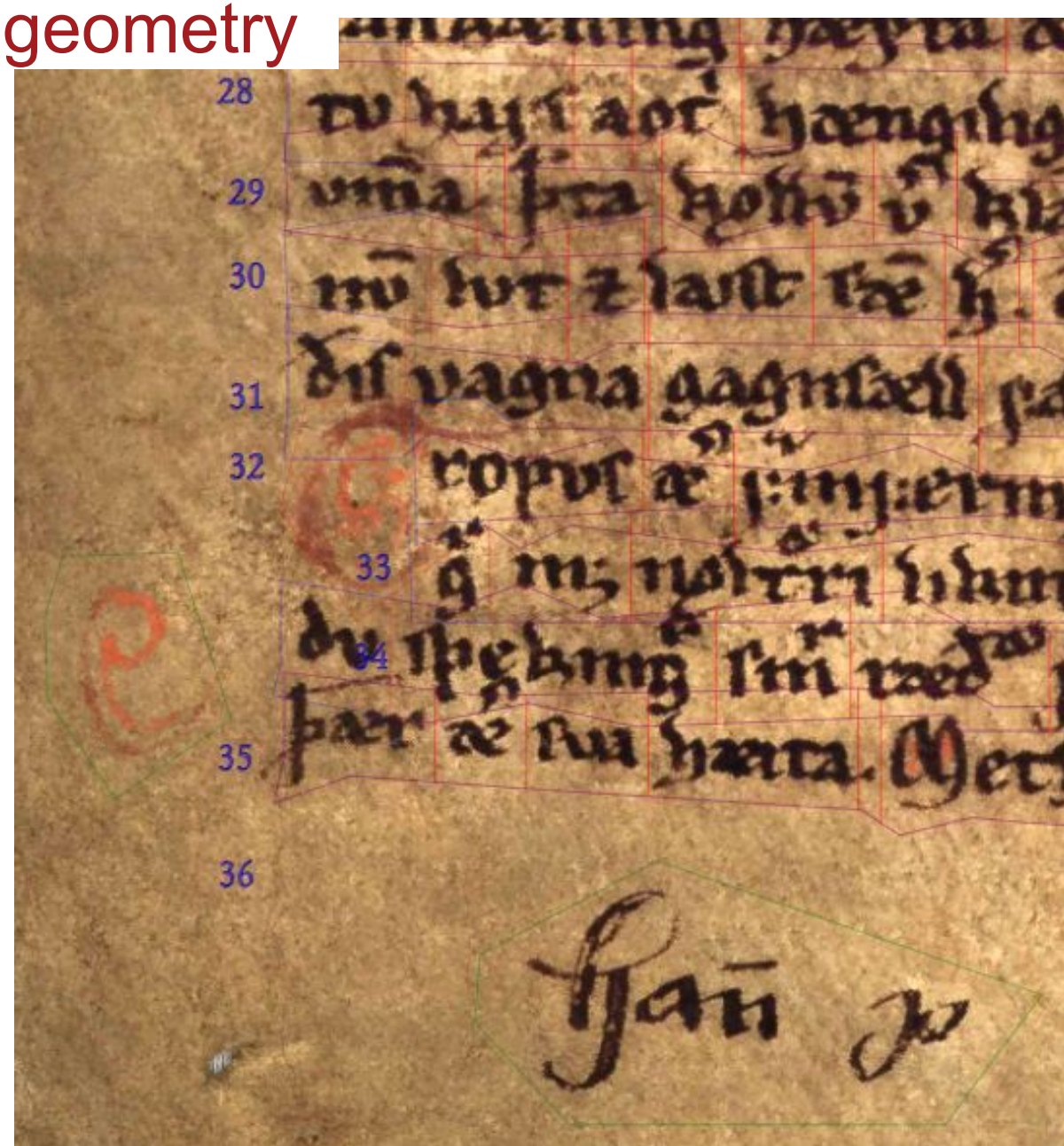
- The hierarchical, ordered structure is everywhere in text
- XML has been largely replaced for data exchange by other standards (esp. JSON)
- But TEI has survived because it is particularly suited to representing textual structure

4. But the manuscript isn't a tree



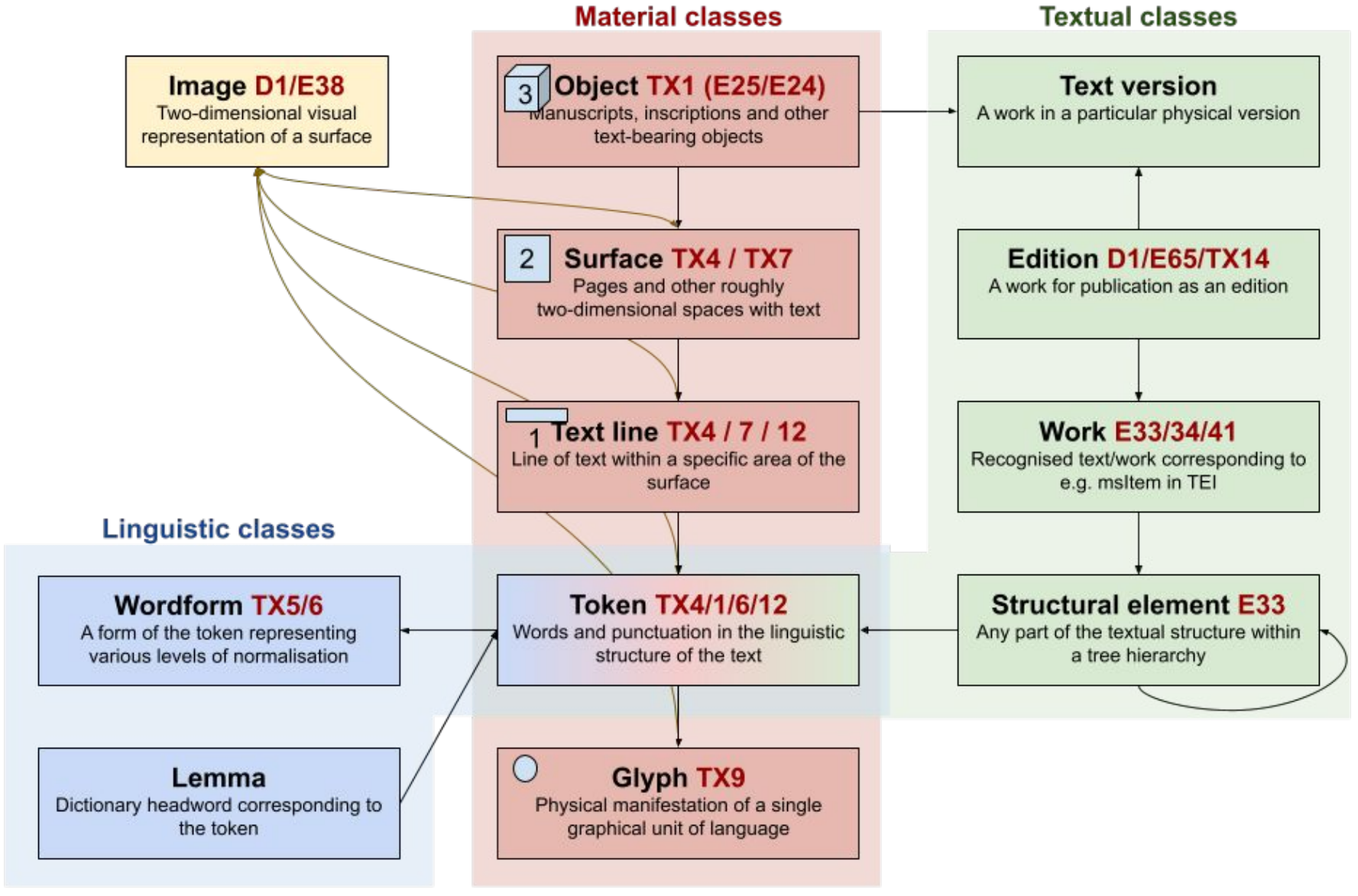
5. The first extension: from XML to geometry



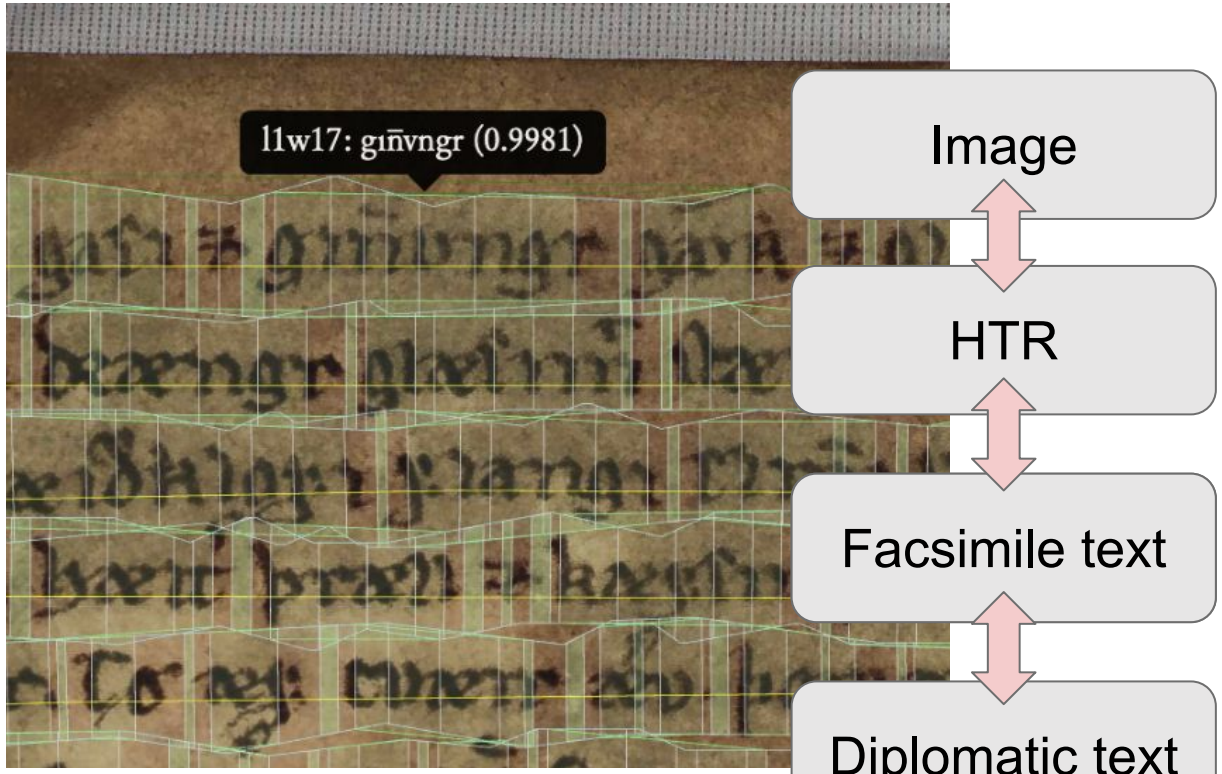


6. Extending (rather than replacing) Menota

E.g. MenotaG / EAE



7. HTR changes the relationship between image and text



Image

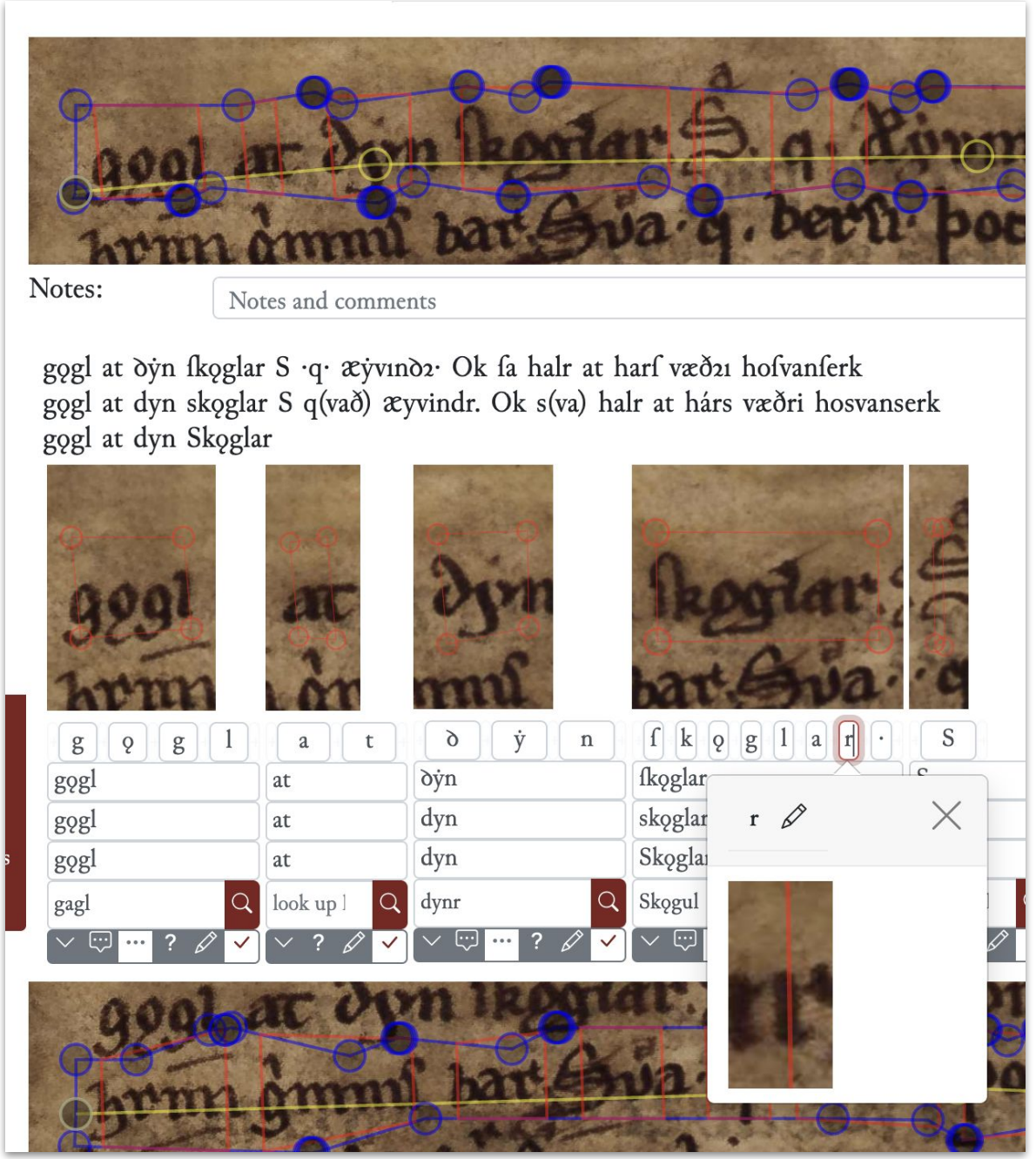
HTR

Facsimile text

Diplomatic text

Translation, POS tagging

Normalised text





8. One text? Or many texts?

MenotaG allows the manuscript-level representations and the editorial representation to coexist rather than forcing everything into a single linear text.

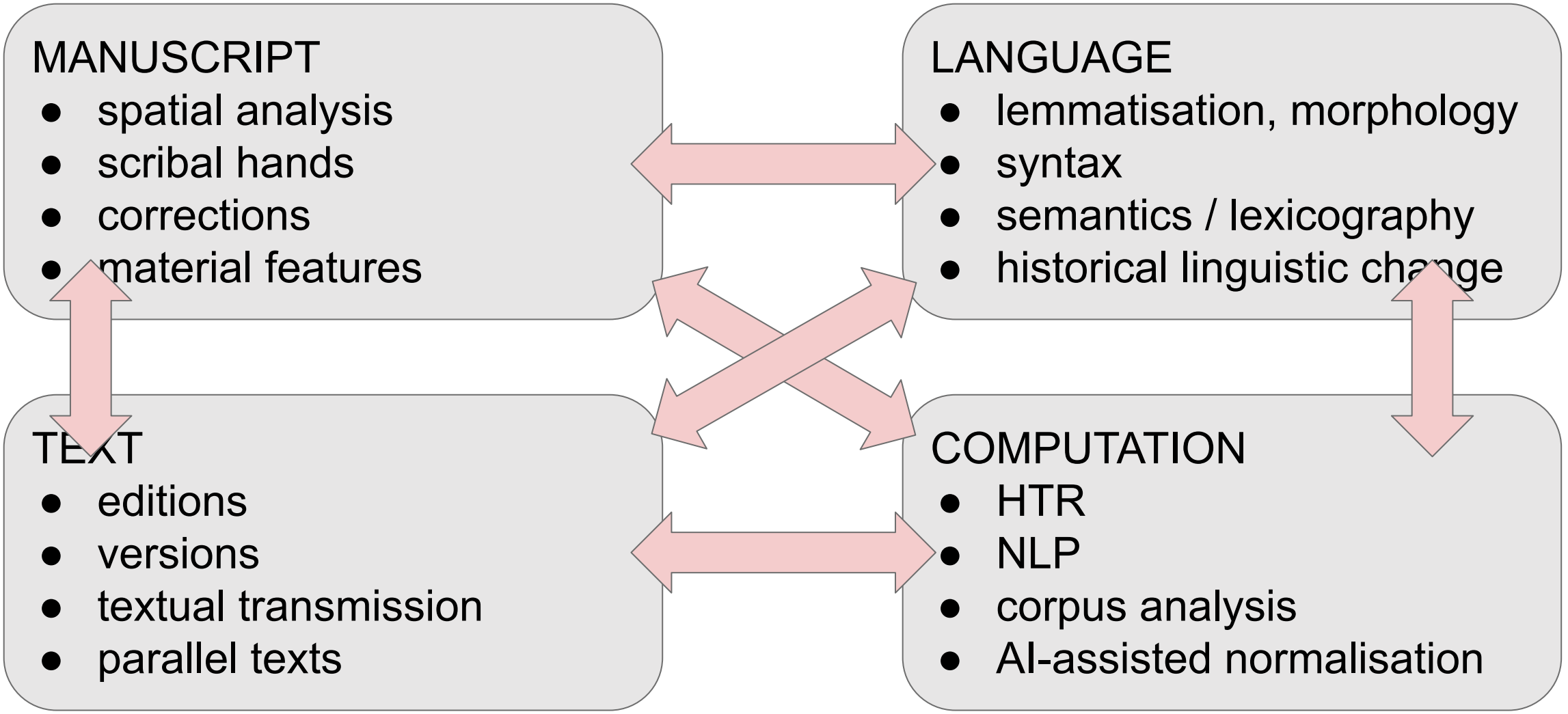
9. From trees to graphs

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 <me:dipl>het</me:dipl>
```

Extending
the tree structure



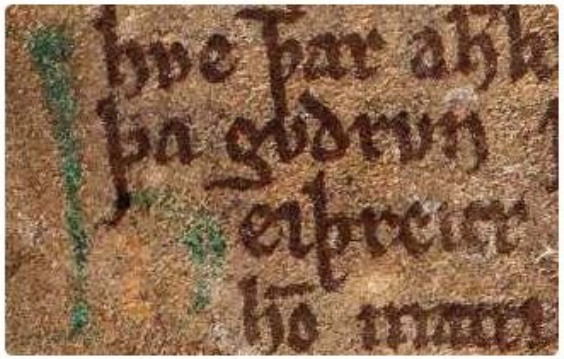
10. What does this enable?



Facsimile | Diplomatic | Norma

1. at brǫðrō ȝ at brynioþō hinćto mic at
2. at ſaxa ſvn mа gm h kan helga hv vel
3. ı ſal gengo aþ kvęn kſ ı ketıl tǫkı. kē
4. hægna ſecka ec ſiþ ſvaſa brǫþ. ſvþı mc
5. ka nv vþ ec ſialf þ mic ſpnia lþta. Brá
6. lóþa ȝ ho vp v toc ıarcna ſteına. ſe nv
7. þın heılagliga hve ſiá hvea vellı. Þló þ
8. tı er h heılar ſa hendɔ gvðrvnar. nv ſ
9. ſv ė gvðrvno gndı uęntı. Saat Ψ arml
10. hve þar a hkıo hendɔ ſvıþnoþo. leıdd
11. þa gvðrvn ſına harma. þ bɔgnþıo ȝ o
12. Þeıþreıcr h. k. , ð. hſ h. bɔgnþ. Vılm
13. hō mattı eg þǫða bɔ́n aþ tıl cō oddr
14. þı verıt vnvſta gvnarſ. g. ſ. vm þa ſag
15. Heþrþa ec ſegıa ı ſagō þɔ́nō hve mę
16. engı matti þ ıɔþ oþan heıþrecſ ð. hı
17. Þ þ oddrvn atla ſpſt at ſv mę haþþı
18. brá hō ꝑ ſtallı ſtıɔ́n bıtloþō ȝ a ſvart
19. Let hō mar þara molð ueg ſlettan v
20. andı. Oc hō ın v gecc endlangan ſal ſ
21. ngō ío. ȝ hō þ ɔ́ða allz þrſt v q. Þva
22. eþ hvat ė hléz hvna lz. h lıgr bɔ́gnþ
23. na þın oddrv vıttv eꝑ þv hıalþ. Þvea
24. leıtað hvı ero bɔ́gnþıar braþar ſótt.
25. hæcſtalða h varþı meþ varmrı blęıo .v.
26. það lepndı. Þęr hþć mło þvigıt þleıra
27. mepıo at ſıtıa. rıct gól oddrv rāmt g
28. at bɔ́gnþıo. knattı męr ȝ mægr moloveg ıþɔ́ſſa. bɔ́ll
29. þæ ın blíþo vıþ bana hægna. þ nā at mła męr þɔ́ſıv

Þeıþreıcr / Heiþreicr / *Heiðrekr

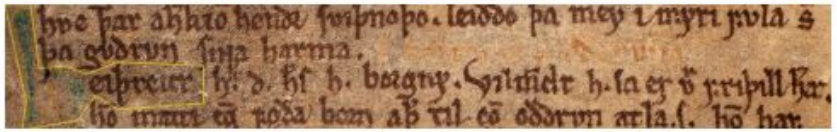


In: (undefined) 31. Frá Borgnýju ok Oddrúnu / (paragraph) 2.

Heiðrekr (noun prop.)

(LP | ONP)

class: noun prop.
case: nom.
gender: m.
num: sg.
spec: indef.

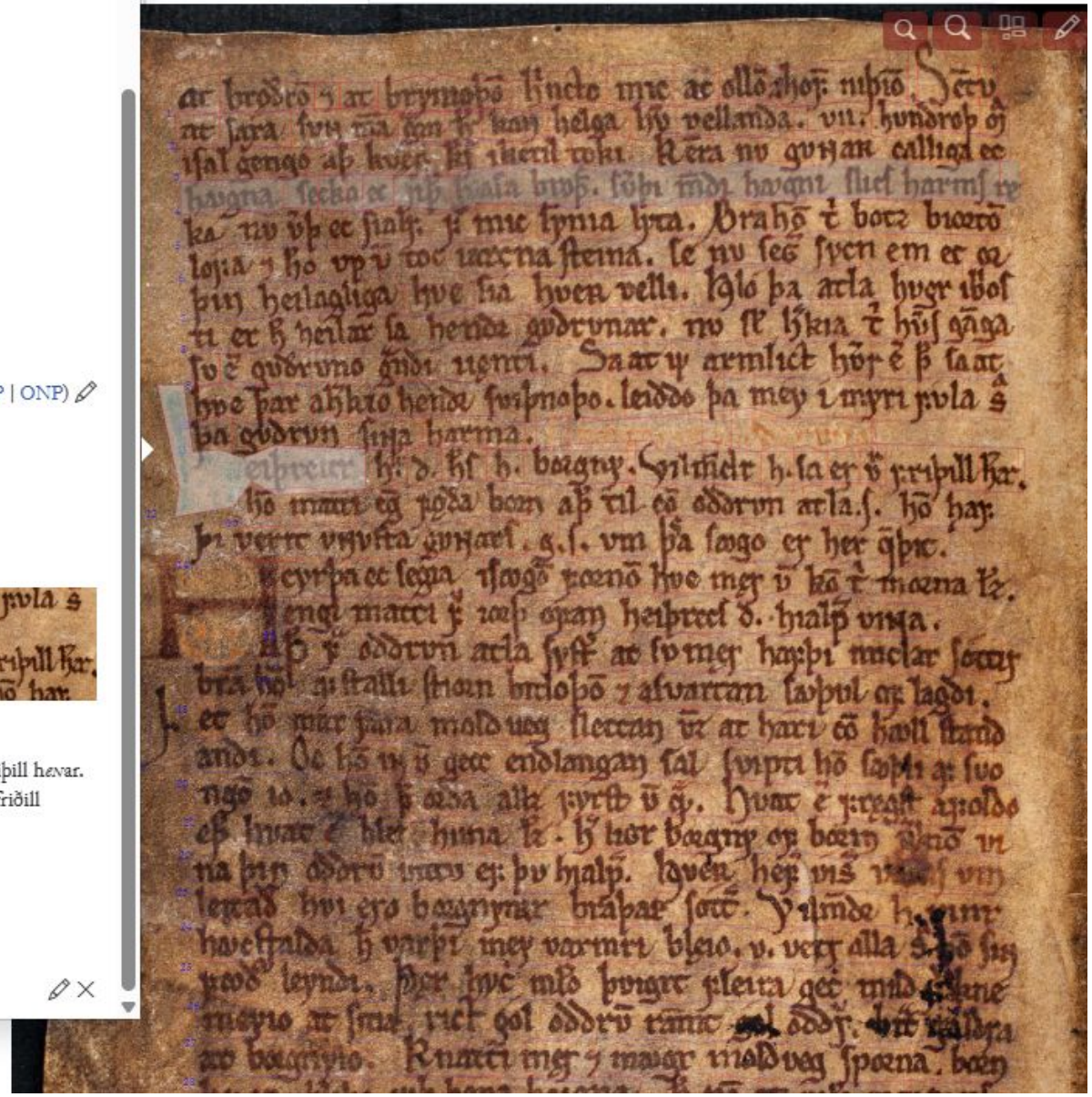


facs **Þeıþreıcr** h. k. , ð. hſ h. bɔ́gnþ. Vılmdr h. ſa er v þrıþıll hæ.
dipl **Heiþreicr** *het konungr.* , *dottir hanſ het* borgnþ. Vilm*v*ndr *het* ſa er *var* friþill h*e*var.
norm ***Heiðrekr** hét konungr; dóttir hans hét Borgný. Vilmundr hét sá er var friðill hennar.

Overlapping features:

region:
decoration: initial, green

HTR duplicate | B&W



11. The next 25 years

